

THE FIVE, AS PEOPLE

v1.2, 2026-08-30. Fable's v1.1 with Stephen's fine-tooth comb applied: all five renamed, four oblique lines rewritten plainly, the boy cut, ten-minute habit. Fable remains blind; this version is Stephen's.

Violet Moore

Violet Moore was forty-four and painted letters for a living. Shop fronts, boat names, the menu boards outside the harbour cafés, and once, for a bet, the side of a bus. She had a unit behind the fish market with a kettle, a radio that is stuck on one station, and a ladder she would not let anyone else climb. On the morning she died the old Regent cinema had three of its six letters back, and the ladder was still chained to the railing under them.

She swam off the slip most mornings from April to November and said it was for her back. It was for the quiet. She ate standing up, fried egg on white, and kept her cash in a large cookie tin because she distrusted the bank and, more than that, invoicing. She was owed money all over town and forgot nobody who owed it. She read the last page of a book first. She smoked two cigarettes a day behind the unit and lied about it with total confidence. She had a favourite brush that she had made herself, sable on a handle cut from a broken oar, green electrical tape at the ferrule, and you could pick it out of a bucket from across the road.

She was funny in a way that cost you something: she ranked people's handwriting out loud and told you the truth about your kitchen. She was halfway through a thing with the council about parking, a thing with her sister about their mother's house, and a thing with the cinema owner about the colour of the R. None of it is finished. That is how you know she was there.

Liam Bryce

Liam Bryce, forty-six, runs the crane at the boatyard and has known Violet since they were eleven and shared a school bus. He is the only one who met her mother, and so the only one who knew Violet before she was good at anything: loud, badly dressed, in trouble. He drove her to the hospital the night her mother went in for the last time, and neither of them ever mentioned it. He swims off the slip because she did and hates it. On a Tuesday he came to the unit at half twelve, ate whatever she was eating, and said nothing for twenty minutes. She called it his visit. He owns a third of the yard, bought quietly eight years ago, and lets the town think he is staff. He has a real tenor voice and uses it only in the crane cab with the door shut.

Frightened, Liam gets tidy. He cleans tools that are already clean. He writes lists and loses them. He runs a thumb along the edge of a table before he sits at it. He goes very reasonable, which is worse than shouting, because you can hear him deciding what not to say.

He thinks Margo is sound, if cold, and would trust her with paper. He thinks Brad is a kid Violet collected, and that she would have got bored of him. He has never liked Ruby; her kindness, he thinks, is a way of being in charge. It has a date: August 2014, Violet's kitchen, a bottle open. One of them asked what would happen to her mother's house, the other answered for her, and Violet laughed. Twelve years on, each of them is still certain she was laughing at the other.

Ruby Walker

Ruby Walker, thirty-nine, is the practice nurse at the surgery on Wharf Street and joined the slip swimmers nine years ago because a patient said it helped. Violet told her she swam like someone being chased. They were firm friends within weeks. Every Tuesday Ruby texted at six to say she couldn't make the slip, and every Tuesday she came, and the two of them sat in the car with the heater on. The argument was always the same one: whether Ruby's husband should be told. Ruby is the one Violet rang at four in the morning, once, three years ago. Ruby drove over. They never talked about what was said, and when Ruby tried, Violet changed the subject so fast it was like a door closing. Ruby has not had a drink in six years. She holds a tonic and lets them assume gin, and it has never come up. She had grade eight piano at fourteen and lets the surgery think the Christmas carols are the extent of it.

Frightened, Ruby talks. She fills the room, allocates jobs, makes tea nobody asked for. She ends her own sentences with "anyway", as if handing them over. Underneath it she is counting exits. She reads bodies for a living, can tell a lie from the neck, and has stopped trusting that since Violet died: she stood in that kitchen a hundred times and saw nothing.

She loves Brad without quite respecting him. She finds Margo hard work and honest. She has never liked Liam. She thinks his silence is a performance, and that Violet fell for it for thirty years.

Margo Rivera

Margo Rivera, fifty-three, does the accounts for half the harbour and did Violet's for free, which Violet resented. They met when Violet lettered the office door and undercharged, and Margo posted a cheque for the difference with a note that said "don't be a martyr". That was fourteen years ago. Margo does not swim. She stands on the slip with a flask. The three think she can't; she swam for the county at fifteen and has never corrected them. Every Tuesday she left a bag of Violet's receipts on the counter at the unit for sorting, and every Friday she collected it untouched and sorted them herself. It had been a joke once. Every second Sunday she drives two hours up the coast to a woman called Tessa. Eleven years. None of the three has heard the name. Margo is the one who knew about the money. Violet had more than anyone would guess, and not from painting letters, and Margo knows where from. She has told nobody and does not intend to.

Frightened, Margo gets sharp. She says the true thing in the worst way. She has made Ruby cry twice since the funeral and apologised once. She is ten minutes early to everything, always ten, and sits in the car until the hour. She sleeps restlessly and does sums at three in the morning that come out the same every time.

She rates Liam. She finds Ruby exhausting and right about most things. She has never liked Brad. She thinks he was Violet's project, and that projects should always end.

Brad Collins

Brad Collins, thirty-four, is a signwriter, his own van, his own customers, some of them once hers. He turned up at the unit seven years ago, a design teacher then, asking Violet to teach him. She refused, then did it anyway, Tuesday evenings, for money at first and then for nothing. Here a second signwriter is one thing to the first: she sent him the jobs she did not want, boat names in a hurry, the pub that changed its name every spring, and he said thank you. When she was behind she sent him up the ladder she would not let anyone climb. He swims badly and only in summer and she never let him hear the end of it. He is the only one she

talked to about the other three, and has told nobody what she said: it would make him look like what Margo says he is. He ran a marathon under three hours in spring and told them it was a wedding.

Frightened, Brad jokes. Then he drinks. Then he goes still in a way that is not calm, and if you speak to him then he will answer a question you didn't ask. He puts his keys on the table when he sits and moves them twice.

He likes Margo, which she does not believe. He thinks Ruby is the best of them and the easiest to lie to. He has never known what to do with Liam, who reads him the way a man reads the bottom of an invoice, and he has stopped trying.